Improving Recruitment at UCT Stay & Connect

A Hospitality Recruitment Process and System Design Case Study

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Designing a recruitment process that is easier to understand, operate and hand over.

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1 Stay & Connect and the Operational Context

Stay & Connect is a division of the University of Cape Town that promotes and manages bookable university spaces and related services. Its mandate includes managing bookings and their arrangements, and delivering memorable experiences for customers and guests on campus [1].

Its services extend beyond vacation accommodation.

Service	**What it involves**
Holiday accommodation	Accommodation for individuals, families, tour groups and teams during vacation periods
Student vacation accommodation	Accommodation for UCT students staying during university vacations
All Africa House	B&B accommodation for visiting academics, researchers, conference delegates and other visitors
Venues and events	Spaces for conferences, seminars, functions and related events
Sports facilities	Indoor and outdoor spaces for activities and organised events
Film locations	Campus locations for filming and photography

These offerings serve tourists, tour operators, event organisers, university affiliates and other visitors [1, 3].

The vacation-accommodation operation can involve large groups, catering arrangements, access control and coordinated arrivals. The official group-travel page advertises a portfolio of more than 6,000 beds across more than 20 residences, with availability depending on the vacation period [2].

Stay & Connect also offers conference-management support, including registration, on-site coordination, transport, accommodation arrangements and financial administration [4].

This report focuses on recruitment for the vacation-accommodation operation within that broader hospitality service.

1.1 Recruiting Student Professionals Within UCT

In the vacation-accommodation operation in which I worked, Stay & Connect recruits UCT students into paid hospitality roles. These students work as student professionals, carrying responsibilities that contribute directly to the guest experience and daily operation.

The roles considered in this project include Receptionist / Assistant and Night Manager.

Recruitment therefore needs to identify more than whether someone has submitted a form. The team needs to assess availability, relevant experience, role requirements and supporting evidence before making appointments.

The system is designed to support that assessment and coordination process. It does not replace the judgement of the recruitment team.

2 How the Improvement Started

During my part-time work in vacation accommodation, I noticed that recruitment involved much more than receiving applications.

The team needed to check documents, evaluate candidates, arrange interviews, communicate decisions and confirm who would work in each role. These activities sat behind the application form and required continued attention from administrators and managers.

The existing process used Google Forms. Each recruitment period required the forms and supporting process to be set up or adapted again. Once applications arrived, staff still had to manage the evaluation and follow-up work.

That was the part I wanted to improve.

Applicants needed a clear way to apply, but administrators also needed a readable workspace for understanding each application and completing the recruitment process.

I therefore designed a reusable recruitment pilot around the work the team needed to do, from publishing a role to confirming an appointment.

3 The Original Process

3.1 Receiving Applications

Google Forms provided a familiar way to collect application information. Students could enter their details and submit responses for review.

However, receiving those responses did not complete the recruitment process.

Staff still needed to connect each candidate's answers with evidence, assessment notes, interview arrangements and the eventual outcome.

3.2 Work Required After Submission

For each candidate, the recruitment team needed to:

1. identify the candidate and the role applied for;
2. read the application;
3. inspect supporting evidence;
4. check eligibility and missing information;
5. record the review outcome;
6. decide whether to shortlist the candidate;
7. arrange and communicate an interview;
8. record the assessment;
9. prepare and communicate a decision; and
10. confirm the appointment and resolve alternatives.

Where these steps were managed separately, staff had to maintain the relationship between the application, documents, messages and decisions themselves.

3.3 Disadvantages of the Existing Workflow

Repeated setup. Each season required the intake process and its supporting arrangements to be prepared or adapted again.

Difficult back-office evaluation. A response list did not automatically organise the candidate's evidence, completed checks, assessment and next action into one working view.

Information spread across steps. Staff needed to connect submitted answers with documents, correspondence and later decisions.

Coordination between roles. A student applying for more than one role needed to be recognised across those applications.

Communication effort. Messages needed to remain consistent with the latest decision, especially when a candidate was being considered for several roles.

Handover effort. Another administrator needed to understand what had already happened and what remained outstanding.

Google Forms can be copied and automated. The issue was the overall workflow being used, rather than a claim that Forms cannot support recruitment.

4 What I Set Out to Improve

My aim was to make recruitment reusable, readable and easier to coordinate.

The objectives were to:

- configure new recruitment rounds without rebuilding the application;
- make candidate information easier for administrators to read;
- connect evidence checks to decisions;
- show application progress clearly;
- give applicants a straightforward submission and follow-up experience;
- coordinate interviews and communication;
- prevent conflicting active allocations; and
- leave documentation for the next operator.

The administrator experience was central to the design. Improving the application page alone would not resolve the work involved in evaluating and appointing candidates afterwards.

5 Prioritising Administrator Readability

5.1 Designing for the Person Doing the Work

Administrators may review many applications, return to interrupted work and coordinate with colleagues.

The interface should help them understand a record without interpreting database structures or reconstructing the candidate's history from separate sources.

I organised the workspace around:

- Applications;
- Interviews;
- Decisions;
- Communications;
- Rounds & roles; and
- Settings.

The goal was to help staff answer six practical questions:

1. Who is this candidate?
2. Which role are they applying for?
3. What evidence has been checked?
4. What is missing?
5. What stage are they at?
6. What should happen next?

5.2 Readability and Willingness to Use the System

I wanted the workspace to make recruitment feel more manageable.

Clear labels, organised information and visible progress can reduce the effort needed to understand a task before acting. The intention was to encourage staff to work through the process confidently and return to it without having to relearn where information was located.

Design choice	**Intended benefit**
Clear status labels	Distinguish applications that are received, shortlisted, interviewed, offered or appointed
Selected-round view	Focus attention on the relevant recruitment period
Connected review workflow	Bring answers, evidence checks and actions into the same process
Consistent layout	Make controls and working patterns easier to recognise
Communication previews	Allow inspection before messages are released
Visible outstanding work	Help staff identify what still needs attention

These are design intentions. The report does not claim that administrator motivation or productivity has already been measured.

Staff feedback and task-based usability testing are needed to establish whether the interface achieves those aims.

6 The Proposed Workflow

The revised process connects application intake to the later recruitment stages.

1. The owner creates a recruitment round.
2. Staff configure and publish its roles.
3. Applicants browse vacancies and verify their email.
4. Applicants submit answers and supporting PDFs.
5. Staff review the application and evidence.
6. Eligible candidates are shortlisted.
7. Invitations are reviewed and released.
8. Candidates book available interview slots.
9. Staff record interview assessments.
10. Offers are prepared and released.
11. Candidates accept or decline.
12. Staff confirm appointments and close alternatives.

The system records and checks the workflow. Recruitment decisions remain with the authorised staff.

7 Who Benefits

7.1 Student Applicants

Students can browse published opportunities, submit their information and return to their own application.

They can respond to information requests, book a released interview and respond to a released offer.

Their portal excludes internal reviewer notes, assessment scores and other applicants' records.

7.2 Administrators and Reviewers

Administrators receive a task-based workspace for evaluating candidates and recording progress.

The intended benefit is less effort spent assembling information before making a decision, with clearer checks and outstanding actions.

7.3 Managers and Future Operators

Managers can oversee rounds, roles, capacity and appointments.

The source package and runbooks also support continuity. Another operator should be able to understand setup and daily operation without relying entirely on the original developer.

8 Technology Options and Selection

Option	Strength	Trade-off
Forms and Sheets automation	Familiar intake with a smaller change	A richer review workspace still needs development
Apps Script and HTML	Direct Google integration	Account quotas and bounded pilot storage
Low-code application	Can speed up interface development	Licensing and features require review
Microsoft-based workflow	Potential institutional fit	Tenant permissions and integrations need confirmation
Custom backend and database	Greater control over scale and jobs	More deployment and maintenance work

I selected Google Apps Script for the personal-account pilot because it offered a practical way to connect a browser interface with storage and communication without maintaining a separate application server.

This was a pilot choice. Institutional operation may require different storage, email or calendar services.

9 Why HTML Was Used

HTML defines the page structure, CSS controls presentation and JavaScript handles interaction.

Plain HTML was sufficient for the forms, lists, review screens and communication controls in this version. It avoided an additional frontend build pipeline and framework dependencies.

This allowed the interface work to focus on readable information and understandable actions.

The browser communicates with Apps Script through `google.script.run` [5]. The recruitment rules remain in `Code.gs`.

The HTML displays information and sends commands. The server checks identity, ownership, evidence requirements and permitted stage changes.

10 System Architecture

10.1 Two Entry Points, One System

The pilot uses two deployments from one Apps Script project [6]:

- a private owner-administrator link; and

- an applicant-facing link.

Both use the same recruitment engine and data.

Additional authorised staff can use the administrator sign-in page served through the applicant deployment.

A page parameter selects the interface. It does not grant access to administrative functions.

10.2 Component Responsibilities

Component	Responsibility
Administrator HTML	Review, scheduling, decisions and communication
Applicant HTML	Vacancies and personal application actions
Code.gs	Rules, identity checks, persistence and integrations
Google Sheets	Recruitment and authentication snapshots
Google Drive	Private supporting PDFs
MailApp	Sign-in codes and recruitment messages
Google Calendar	Optional events in the owner's calendar

11 Data Design and Recruitment Rules

A person is separate from an application. One student may apply for several roles, while an allocation records their active offer or appointment in a round.

Applications retain their submission-time role configuration so later template changes do not silently alter the requirements under which someone applied.

The central allocation rule is:

At most one active allocation per person per round.

An active allocation includes an offered, accepted or appointed role.

Preparing an offer reserves capacity and places alternatives on hold. Acceptance requires a released offer. Appointment closes alternatives. Declining releases the reservation and restores held applications.

These checks run on the server.

12 Identity, Documents and Storage

12.1 Identity

Sign-in uses a six-digit emailed code. It expires after ten minutes, is single-use and permits at most five incorrect attempts.

Email verification confirms control of an inbox. Staff still need to verify student identifiers, eligibility and supporting evidence.

12.2 Documents

The server checks PDF headers and upload sizes. These checks do not establish document authenticity.

Evidence is delivered through authorised download functions. Applicants do not receive access to the complete evidence folder or database.

12.3 Persistence

Recruitment snapshots are stored in `_State`; authentication snapshots are stored in `_Auth`.

The writer completes the snapshot pieces before publishing the new pointer. A script lock coordinates mutations, while administrator revision checks reject stale saves.

Whole-state storage becomes more expensive as records grow. Historical snapshots are not independent backups.

Applicant updates do not have the same expected-revision protection as administrator edits. Multiple applicant tabs can overwrite an earlier answer update.

13 Communication and Scheduling

Applications are saved before receipt delivery is attempted. Other messages are prepared for staff review and release.

The sender rechecks whether a message matches the current outcome.

If sending becomes uncertain, the message is marked for inspection rather than automatically resent.

Interview booking checks protect occupied slots and detect overlapping candidate or panel bookings. Consistent panel names are important for those checks.

Optional Calendar integration creates events in the owner's calendar without automatically inviting guests.

14 Cost and Operating Constraints

14.1 Hosting

The Google pilot does not require a separately hosted application server.

A personal-account demonstration can run within available service allowances without an additional hosting subscription. Support, storage and any account subscription still have costs.

14.2 Email Capacity

Google currently lists Apps Script allowances of 100 email recipients per day for consumer accounts and 1,500 for eligible Workspace accounts [7].

Sign-in codes and recruitment messages share that allowance.

For an illustrative intake of 300 candidates:

$$300 \times (\text{one code} + \text{one receipt}) = 600 \text{ recipient sends.}$$

Two further messages per candidate would bring the scenario to:

$$300 \times 4 = 1{,}200 \text{ recipient sends.}$$

These are demand calculations, not demonstrated throughput.

14.3 Implementation Limits

The code also imposes:

- a default of 50 global sign-in requests per day, with a code maximum of 200;
- a global sign-in cap of 20 requests per hour;
- global upload-attempt caps of 20 per hour and 50 per day;
- up to three PDFs per upload request, at most 2 MB each and 4 MB combined;
- a four-million-character active-state limit; and
- communication batches of up to thirty selected messages.

There is no background email worker or automatic retention process. The pilot therefore needs active monitoring and a bounded intake plan.

15 Institutional Fit

UCT's published service information describes Microsoft email and calendar arrangements and account-specific Google storage limits [8].

Its storage FAQ identifies restrictions on university-owned confidential or sensitive information in cloud solutions [9].

The personal-account build is a technical pilot. Institutional use requires confirmation of ownership, permitted storage, sender identity, backup and retention arrangements.

The recruitment workflow can remain useful even where the underlying integrations need to change.

16 Testing and Current Outcome

The concrete output is a reusable source package with separate administrator and applicant experiences.

Local checks passed for:

1. preventing competing offers;
2. reserving role capacity;
3. requiring offer release before acceptance;

4. closing alternatives on appointment;
5. releasing capacity after decline; and
6. rejecting overlapping panel bookings.

Source and browser-script syntax were also checked.

These checks did not establish live Google delivery, deployed performance, administrator usability or institutional approval.

No completed recruitment-round before-and-after measurement is included.

17 Evaluating the Improvement

The next evaluation should include the administrators who will operate the system.

Measure	**What to examine**
Review time	Time to find evidence and record an outcome
Readability	Whether staff can identify the candidate, stage and next action without assistance
Task completion	Whether review, invitation and offer tasks can be completed correctly
Administrative effort	Repeated follow-ups and corrections
Staff feedback	Clarity, workload, confidence and willingness to continue using the workspace
Reliability	Quota interruptions, conflicting saves and uncertain deliveries

For comparable tasks:

$$\text{Time reduction} = \frac{T_{\text{before}} - T_{\text{after}}}{T_{\text{before}}} \times 100\%.$$

This should use measured task times. The effect of readability should be evaluated rather than assumed.

18 My Contribution and Skills Demonstrated

Skill	**How I applied it**
Problem identification	Recognised the work required after application submission
User-centred design	Prioritised administrator readability alongside the applicant experience
Technical judgement	Selected a practical pilot stack and explained its constraints
Data modelling	Separated people, applications and allocations
Workflow design	Connected review, interviews, communication and appointments
Testing	Checked important allocation and scheduling behaviour locally
Documentation	Prepared installation and operations guides for reuse

19 Reflection and Next Steps

I started with a process I had seen while working in hospitality. I wanted to make it easier for the students applying and the staff managing recruitment.

The important lesson was that the administrator's experience deserves as much attention as the application page. Staff need to read the record, understand what has happened and complete the next action confidently.

I would next complete an authorised Google integration test and ask administrators to carry out representative tasks.

Their feedback would guide improvements to layout, wording and workflow. A small recruitment round could then provide measured evidence of the benefits and remaining constraints.

20 Supporting Documents and Evidence

This report is supported by:

- an installation runbook;
- an operations runbook; and
- the source folder containing Code.gs, the HTML templates and configuration example.

The configuration example is a checklist, not an automatic import.

The following evidence can be added:

- redacted records of the original Forms-based workflow;
- administrator and applicant interface screenshots;
- live integration-test results;
- administrator feedback; and
- measured operational outcomes.

References

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